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HAND IN HAND Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge releasing the party manifesto along with Sonia and Priyanka Gandhi, Ashok Gehlot and Sachin Pilot in Jaipur, Apr. 6

gender outreach is part of this. "If the *ghar ki lakshmi* (women) decides that the vote should go to Modiji, as he gave a 33 per cent reservation to women in legislatures, then none in the household can do otherwise," says Diya Kumari. Meanwhile, Bhajan Lal, with not much to boast about yet beyond a crackdown on exam paper leaks and illegal mining, has deftly woven his campaign around an everyman image. Public hearings are a staple, as are impromptu roadside *chai per charcha*s, where he lends an empathetic ear to the travails of bureaucratic harassment endured by the average citizen. Between a talismanic two-time PM going for a historic third term and a first-time MLA as CM, the BJP has covered both ends of the spectrum.

In 2019, the BJP juggernaut had swept through the state with an average victory margin of 340,000 votes per seat. Amid speculations of a dip in the BJP vote share this time,

WHILE THE BJP'S CANDIDATE SELECTION HAS BEEN MARKED BY PRAGMATISM AND CALCULATED RISK, A BLUNDER-PRONE CONGRESS IS FOCUSING ON GETTABLE TARGETS

political observers expect the Congress to mount a challenge across at least half-a-dozen constituencies. The Grand Old Party, on its part, harbours aspirations of expanding the battleground to some 9-12 seats, and cornering at least a fistful. Acutely aware of the factors that could undermine its quest for a hat trick of clean sweeps, the BJP has marshalled its resources to fortify these potential weak links.

For one, the BJP has defied preconceived notions in choosing candidates. Consider Mahima Singh, who is married into Mewar's erstwhile royal family. A political novice, she will contest from Rajsamand, following in the footsteps of her husband, Vishvaraj, who won his maiden electoral battle from Nathdwara in the 2023 assembly polls. Amid murmurs of discontent within Rajput ranks, the BJP's overture towards Maharana Pratap's direct descendants appears to be a calculated effort to shore up support among this crucial demographic. Signs of a potentially harmful disaffection in the community towards the BJP have been visible from Gujarat to Uttar Pradesh, but Rajasthan had been first off the blocks there when the new CM's anti-mining drive hit the hotelier-cum-sand mining major Meghraj Singh Shekhawat, a popular community figure, back in mid-February (*A Raging Sandstorm*, March 11).

That has forced the party's new pragmatism towards Rajputs. Beyond